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Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand Registration Guide

Your complete guide to professional registration in New Zealand — explained in plain English, for internationally qualified physiotherapists.



Welcome to your registration guide

For most internationally qualified physiotherapists, registration with the Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand is the very first step on the road to working here — and it usually needs to happen **before** you can apply for jobs.

That order surprises a lot of people. In many countries you find a job first and sort out the paperwork afterwards. New Zealand works the other way around: an employer generally wants to see that you are registrable — or already registered — before they progress your application. Understanding that early changes how you plan everything that follows.

This guide explains the process from beginning to end, built from practical experience supporting internationally qualified healthcare professionals through registration. It focuses on the things that genuinely make a difference: choosing the right pathway, evidencing your competencies against the Practice Thresholds, and avoiding the small mistakes that quietly add weeks to an application.

How to use this guide

Read it once from start to finish to understand the shape of the journey, then keep it nearby and return to each section as you reach it. Think of it as a handbook rather than a leaflet.

An important note

This guide is designed to **complement, not replace**, the official guidance published by the Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand. The Board sets the rules and makes all registration decisions. Where there is ever any difference between this guide and the Board's own published requirements, the Board's guidance always takes precedence. Ethicare supports and guides you through the process; we do not make registration decisions on the Board's behalf.

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A quick word before you start

Registration can feel daunting from the outside, but it is a structured, predictable process. Almost every delay we see comes down to a handful of avoidable issues — and this guide is organised specifically to help you sidestep them.

Understanding the Physiotherapy Board

The Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand (PBNZ) — Te Poari Tiaki Tinana o Aotearoa — is the regulator responsible for the registration and oversight of physiotherapists in New Zealand.

The Board operates under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act, the legislation that governs regulated health professions across New Zealand. Its core purpose is straightforward but important: **to protect the public** by making sure that everyone practising as a physiotherapist is suitably qualified, competent and fit to do so.

Why registration is required

In New Zealand, the title and practice of physiotherapy are **legally protected**. You cannot lawfully practise — or call yourself a physiotherapist — without being registered with the Board and holding a current Annual Practising Certificate. This is not a bureaucratic formality; it is the mechanism that assures patients, employers and colleagues that you have met a recognised national standard.

Top tip

Because registration generally comes before employment, treat it as the foundation of your whole relocation plan. Everything else — job offers, visa, relocation — sits on top of it.

The Practice Thresholds

One thing that sets physiotherapy apart from some other professions is *what* you're assessed against. Every application is measured against the **Physiotherapy Practice Thresholds in Australia and Aotearoa New Zealand** — a shared set of competencies describing what a physiotherapist must be able to do, safely and effectively, to register and practise. It's worth getting to know these early; they are the yardstick your whole application is held to. We cover them in detail in Section 04.

Registration vs. the APC

Two related but separate things. **Registration** confirms you have met the standard to practise and does not expire. The **Annual Practising Certificate (APC)** is what then permits you to actually work, and it must be renewed each year. Think of registration as your licence and the APC as keeping that licence current. You must hold a valid APC at all times while practising; the physiotherapy APC year runs to **31 March** and is managed through the Board's MyPBNZ portal.

Your HPI number & ongoing responsibilities

Once registered, you'll be added to the public New Zealand Register of Physiotherapists, and the Ministry of Health issues you a **Health Practitioner Index (HPI) number** that identifies you across the health system. Registration is an ongoing commitment: you're expected to maintain your competence, practise ethically, and complete **Continuing Professional Development (CPD)** each year, which the Board can audit.



Scopes of practice

The Board registers physiotherapists into defined **scopes of practice**. For internationally qualified applicants, one matters above all others to begin with.

The three scopes

There are three scopes of practice for physiotherapists in New Zealand: the **General Scope**, the **Advanced Practice Physiotherapist (APP) Scope**, and the **Specialist Scope**. The important point for anyone moving to New Zealand is that **every physiotherapist must first be registered under the General Scope** — it is the foundation for everything else.

General Scope

This is where all physiotherapists begin, and the scope your international application will be for. It covers the full breadth of autonomous physiotherapy practice — assessment, diagnosis and treatment — across musculoskeletal, neurological, cardiorespiratory and other areas.

Advanced Practice Physiotherapist (APP) Scope

A scope for physiotherapists demonstrating advanced skills in areas such as musculoskeletal, neurology or cardiorespiratory practice. It is **not an entry point**: to register in it you must already hold unrestricted General Scope registration, a current APC, a relevant postgraduate qualification, and meet experience requirements including time practising in New Zealand.

Specialist Scope

The most advanced scope, for physiotherapists recognised as specialists in their field. Like the APP scope, it builds on General Scope registration and New Zealand practice — it is something to progress toward over time, not a route in.

What this means for you

If you're applying from overseas, your application is for the **General Scope**. The APP and Specialist scopes are progression options you can pursue later, once you've registered, obtained an APC and built experience in New Zealand. There's no need to think about them yet — but it's reassuring to know the career pathway is there.

Which registration pathway is yours

This is the single most important thing to get right at the start. Unlike some regulators, PBNZ has **three distinct pathways**, and which one you use depends entirely on where you trained and where you're registered.

Pathway 1 — International Express Pathway

Who it's for: physiotherapists connected to the **UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa**. You qualify for this faster route if you either currently hold unrestricted registration as a physiotherapist in one of those four countries, *or* hold a physiotherapy qualification from one of them that's recognised as a pre-registration qualification by that country's regulator. In practice that means evidence either from a UK/Ireland/Canada/SA institution, or proof of registration with **HCPC, CORU, HPCSA or a Canadian physiotherapy regulator**.

Why it exists: the Board has identified these four jurisdictions as having requirements closely aligned with New Zealand's, so the Express Pathway removes the duplication of things you've already proven. It is designed to be more efficient and less onerous.

Pathway 2 — Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition (TTMR)

Who it's for: physiotherapists who hold registration with **AHPRA in Australia**.

Why it exists: under the Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition arrangement, registration in one country is recognised in the other. If this is you, you apply under TTMR rather than as an overseas-trained applicant.

Pathway 3 — International General Pathway

Who it's for: everyone else — physiotherapists who do **not** hold a recognised qualification or unrestricted registration in the UK, Ireland, Canada, South Africa or Australia.

Why it exists: this pathway assesses your qualification and competence directly against the Practice Thresholds, with a structured process to demonstrate any competencies your curriculum doesn't already evidence (explained fully in Section 04).

Choosing the wrong pathway costs time

Applying under the wrong pathway is one of the most common avoidable delays. If you trained or are registered in the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa, use the *Express* pathway. If you're AHPRA-registered in Australia, use *TTMR*. Everyone else uses the *General* pathway. If you're unsure where you fall, check before you start — we're happy to help you confirm.

Finding your pathway at a glance

1

Registered with AHPRA in Australia?

Apply under Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition (TTMR).

2

Qualified or registered in the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa?

Apply under the International Express Pathway.

3

Anywhere else?

Apply under the International General Pathway.

The Practice Thresholds & how assessment works

Every PBNZ application is assessed against the same benchmark: the Physiotherapy Practice Thresholds in Australia and Aotearoa New Zealand. Understanding them demystifies the whole process.

What the Practice Thresholds are

The Practice Thresholds describe the **threshold competence** required for initial registration and continuing practice as a physiotherapist — the things you must be able to do, safely and effectively, across areas like assessment, clinical reasoning, intervention, communication, professional behaviour and safety. They are shared across Australia and New Zealand, which is why Australian-registered physiotherapists move so smoothly between the two systems.

How the General Pathway assessment works

The International General Pathway assessment runs through **five phases**. Knowing them in advance removes most of the anxiety, because you can see exactly where you are at any point:

- **Phase 1 — Document Check.** The Board reviews your application for completeness. If anything is missing or there's a question over eligibility, you're emailed before it proceeds.
- **Phase 2 — Qualification Assessment.** An assessor reviews how well the curriculum of your primary physiotherapy degree aligns with each key competency in the Practice Thresholds.
- **Phase 3 — Request for Supporting Evidence** (only if needed). If your curriculum doesn't fully meet the competencies, you're told exactly which ones to demonstrate, and have **3 months** to provide evidence. Competencies already shown don't need proving again.
- **Phase 4 — Assessment of Supporting Evidence.** An assessor reviews what you submitted. If it meets the criteria you proceed; if not, you can submit more based on their feedback.
- **Phase 5 — Registration.** Applications that meet the requirement go to the Registrar for approval, and you receive email confirmation.

The two qualification-assessment outcomes

At the heart of it, Phase 2 has two possible outcomes: if your curriculum **meets** the threshold competence for every key competency, your application goes straight forward for registration; if it **doesn't**, it moves to Phase 3 so you can demonstrate the gaps. Neither outcome is unusual, and the second isn't a judgement on your ability — it simply reflects that curricula differ between countries.

Demonstrating competencies (Phase 3)

If you reach Phase 3, the Board's request sets out precisely which competencies need evidencing. The Board publishes a *Guidance on Providing Supporting Evidence* document plus templates (including a Reflections template and a Validation of Work History form) — read these, as they help you choose high-quality evidence. Your evidence should include specific examples and detail from your training or work as a physiotherapist, named clearly and kept well-organised.

Top tip

Read the Practice Thresholds *before* you apply, and think about how your experience maps to each competency. If you can already see where your curriculum might be light, you can start gathering specific, detailed examples early — which makes the evidence phase far quicker if it arises.

Eligibility requirements

The Board's requirements are far easier to satisfy once you understand **why** each one exists — so that's how we'll explain them.

A recognised physiotherapy qualification

Why it exists: your qualification is the foundation of safe practice. The Board needs confidence that your training covered the competencies in the Practice Thresholds — which is why course content sometimes matters as much as the certificate itself, particularly on the General Pathway.

Registration / good standing

Why it exists: if you're or have been registered as a physiotherapist anywhere, the Board needs to know you're in good standing, with no unresolved concerns. This underpins the Express and TTMR pathways, and supports the General Pathway too.

Recency of practice

Why it exists: skills fade when they aren't used. The Board wants assurance your competence is **current**, not just historical. If you've had a significant break from practice, flag it early — depending on the gap, a Return to Practice process may apply.

English language

Why it exists: clear communication is a patient-safety issue. Physiotherapists must take histories, explain treatment and communicate precisely with patients and colleagues. Evidence of English ability protects everyone (covered in Section 08).

Fitness for registration

Why it exists: this covers your physical and mental fitness to practise safely, and your professional conduct history. Full, honest disclosure — even of matters you think are minor or resolved — is always the right approach; non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than the underlying matter usually is.

Cultural competency

Why it exists: practising safely in New Zealand means understanding its cultural context, including Te Tiriti o Waitangi and Māori health. PBNZ requires evidence of cultural competency training as part of registration — a requirement specific enough that we've given it its own section (Section 07).

Top tip

Read every requirement as a question the Board is trying to answer about your safety to practise. When you frame your evidence as the *answer* to that question, your application becomes far more persuasive.

Preparing your application

A strong application is rarely about doing anything clever — it's about assembling clean, complete, correctly certified documents and presenting them well. Here's what you'll need.

Present it like a professional portfolio

How your application *looks* matters more than people expect. A folder of crooked, poorly photocopied, half-legible documents quietly undermines the picture the Board is forming of you — even when every document is genuine and correct. Use clean, high-resolution colour scans; pages straight and square, not photographed at an angle; nothing cut off at the edges; consistent file naming; and certification done properly the first time.

Identity

Why: confirms your identity and underpins your visa and right to work.

What's accepted: a **passport or birth certificate**, plus a name-change document (marriage certificate, deed poll) if your name differs across documents.

Tip: scan flat, in colour, with all edges visible.

Your qualification documents

Why: your primary physiotherapy qualification is the basis of registration, and on the General Pathway these documents are what the curriculum assessment works from.

What's required on the General Pathway: your **Degree**, your **Academic Transcript**, your **Curriculum**, and a **Clinical Hours Profile** — all four. (On the Express Pathway you instead provide your degree/transcript from a UK/Ireland/Canada/SA institution, or proof of registration with HCPC, CORU, HPCSA or a Canadian regulator.)

Common mistake: sending only the degree and transcript and omitting the curriculum and clinical hours profile — both are required and frequently forgotten.

Certificates of Good Standing (COGS)

Why: these confirm you're in good standing with every physiotherapy regulator you've registered with.

Critical timing: a COGS must be **less than three months old on the date you submit**. Requesting it too early is a frequent, avoidable cause of having to start again.

Tip: line these up to be fresh at submission, not months before.

Police / criminal history certificates

Why: the Board must protect patients, so it checks your background.

What's required: a police certificate from any country you've lived in for more than 12 months in the last ten years since age 18 — and, like COGS, each must be **less than three months old at submission**.

Tip: these can take time to obtain, so balance starting early against the 3-month rule.

Curriculum Vitae (Board template)

Why: your CV evidences your experience and recency of practice.

Common mistake: submitting your own CV format.

Tip: PBNZ requires the CV on **its own downloadable template** — use it and complete it fully, accounting for every period including any gaps.

Certification of your documents

Why: certification confirms a copy is a true likeness of the original.

The rule: each required document must either be **certified**, *or* sent **directly to the Board by the issuing authority**. Translations of any non-English documents must also be provided.

Tip: confirm exactly who is permitted to certify and how the wording must read before you spend money — getting this wrong means doing it twice.

Cultural competency requirements

This is a requirement that surprises many international applicants, so it's worth understanding clearly — and starting early, because it's easy to leave too late.

What's required

As part of registration, PBNZ requires evidence of **cultural competency training** — typically certificates from **two** recognised cultural competency courses. These cover cultural safety, Te Tiriti o Waitangi (the Treaty of Waitangi) and its place in healthcare, and working effectively with Māori and New Zealand's diverse communities.

Why it exists

Safe, effective physiotherapy in New Zealand isn't only about clinical skill — it's about understanding the people and cultural context you're practising within. Te Tiriti o Waitangi is foundational to New Zealand's health system, and cultural safety is treated as a core part of competent practice, not an optional extra. The requirement reflects that.

The accepted courses

You need certificates from **two** of the following three courses:

- **Foundations in Cultural Competency** — offered by Mauri Ora Associates.
- **Foundations Course on Healthcare and The Treaty of Waitangi** — offered by Mauri Ora Associates.
- **Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti eLearning Modules One and Two** — offered by the Ministry of Health (via the Ko Awatea LEARN platform; you'll need to request an account and provide your international registration number).

An easy mistake to make

The Ngā Paerewa course is **Modules One and Two together** — but the two modules combined count **as only ONE** of the two courses you need. In other words, completing Ngā Paerewa alone is not enough; you must pair it with one of the Mauri Ora courses (or complete both Mauri Ora courses). Plan for two distinct courses, not two Ngā Paerewa modules.

Top tip — start these early

Because these are online courses you complete yourself, they're entirely within your control — which makes them one of the easiest things to get done ahead of time. Completing them early means one less thing holding up your application later. Don't leave them to the end.

A genuine head start

Of everything in this guide, cultural competency training is the step you can most easily begin today, before you've gathered a single other document. It's also a meaningful introduction to the healthcare culture you'll be joining — so it's valuable in its own right, not just a box to tick.

English language requirements

English language evidence exists for one reason: patient safety. Clear communication in a clinical setting is non-negotiable, so the Board needs objective assurance of your ability.

How you can meet the requirement

PBNZ accepts several routes to demonstrate English proficiency. Depending on your background, these can include evidence that English was your first language or the language of your education, or a recognised English test. The Board's English language policy sets out exactly which routes apply — check which one fits your situation before assuming you need a test.

IELTS & OET

Where a test is required, the two most widely accepted are **IELTS (Academic)** and the **OET** (the healthcare-specific test many clinicians prefer). Both set minimum scores in each component — a strong overall score won't help if one component falls below the minimum, so prepare evenly across all four.

Validity periods

Common mistake

Language test results expire — typically around two years from the test date. Sitting your test too early, then taking many months to assemble the rest of your application, is a frequent cause of having to sit (and pay for) the test again. Time it to remain valid through to assessment.

Preparing for testing

Even fluent, native English speakers can stumble on test technique. The format, timing and marking criteria reward preparation. Sit a practice test under timed conditions first, identify your weakest component, and focus your effort there. Booking early also matters — test centre availability can be limited.

Completing & submitting your application

Once your documents are gathered, certified and in date, the application itself is largely a matter of careful assembly. Here's the process, step by step.

1

Confirm your pathway

Express, TTMR or General — get this right first (Section 03). It determines what you submit.

2

Complete your cultural competency courses

Ideally already done — they're within your control, so tackle them early.

3

Create your application on MyPBNZ

Work through each section methodically and answer the fitness-for-registration questions accurately.

4

Upload your documents

Clean colour scans, certified where required, CV on the Board's template, clearly named.

5

Pay the fee & submit

Settle the applicable fee, review everything one final time, then submit.

6

Respond to any requests

On the General Pathway you may be asked for competency evidence — reply promptly and completely.

Understanding the fees

Registration involves fees, and it helps to understand what you're paying for. Depending on your pathway and circumstances these can include the **registration / application fee** and, once registered, your **Annual Practising Certificate (APC)**. On top of the Board's own charges there are usually third-party costs — police certificates, cultural competency courses, any English test, and document certification or translation.

As part of an Ethicare package, **APC costs are reimbursed**, so that particular charge needn't fall on you.

Always check the current figures

We've deliberately not printed fee amounts here. The Board publishes its prescribed fees on its website, and these are reviewed and updated periodically — so any figure we quoted could quickly be out of date. Always confirm the current amounts on the Board's official fees schedule before you budget or pay. We're happy to point you to the right page.

After you submit & your APC

Submitting your application is a milestone, not the finish line. Here's what happens next, so there are no surprises.

Assessment

Your application is reviewed against the Practice Thresholds. On the Express and TTMR pathways this is generally quicker; on the General Pathway it may include the competency-evidence phase described in Section 04. Timeframes vary with pathway and how complete your application is — which is exactly why thorough preparation pays off.

Requests for further information

You may be asked for additional documents or competency evidence. This is routine, not a red flag — a fast, complete response is the single biggest thing within your control to keep things moving.

Registration decision

Applications that meet the requirements are sent to the Registrar for approval. Once approved, you're registered in the General Scope and added to the public Register of Physiotherapists, and you're issued your HPI number.

Applying for your APC

Registration alone doesn't let you work — you must then apply for your **Annual Practising Certificate** through MyPBNZ before you can legally practise. As part of this you confirm when you last practised (your recency of practice). Remember the APC year runs to **31 March**, and as part of an Ethicare package its cost is reimbursed.

Finding employment

With registration (or clear registrability) in hand, you're in a strong position to secure a role — and this is where Ethicare's relocation and settlement support takes over from the registration journey.

Common mistakes to avoid

Almost every avoidable delay we see traces back to one of the issues below. Read this as a pre-flight checklist — get these right and your application will move as smoothly as it can.

⚠️ Wrong pathway

Applying via the General Pathway when you qualify for Express, or vice versa. Confirm your pathway first.

⚠️ CV not on the Board template

PBNZ requires its own CV template — your own format will be sent back.

⚠️ Cultural competency left late

These courses are within your control — leaving them to the end needlessly delays everything.

⚠️ Expired Good Standing

COGS requested too early, lapsing before assessment and needing to be reissued.

⚠️ Poor-quality scans

Cropped, blurry or greyscale copies where text or edges are unclear. If the assessor can't read it, it doesn't count.

⚠️ Incorrect certification

Copies certified by the wrong person or with the wrong wording — meaning the work has to be redone.

⚠️ Thin competency evidence

On the General Pathway, vague evidence that doesn't give specific examples mapped to each competency.

✓ The fix for all of these

Confirm your pathway, prepare everything together, and have it reviewed before you submit. Most of these are invisible to the person making them — a second pair of eyes catches them.

Frequently asked questions

These are the questions internationally qualified physiotherapists ask us most often.

Which pathway should I use?

If you're AHPRA-registered in Australia, use TTMR. If you trained or are registered in the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa, use the International Express Pathway. Everyone else uses the International General Pathway. When in doubt, check before you start.

Can I apply for registration before finding a job?

Yes — and in most cases you should. Because registration usually needs to come before employment, starting it early puts you in a far stronger position when roles arise.

What scope will I be registered in?

The General Scope — that's where every physiotherapist begins. The Advanced Practice and Specialist scopes are progression options you can pursue later, once you've registered, hold an APC and have New Zealand experience.

What are the Practice Thresholds?

They're the shared Australia–New Zealand set of competencies your application is assessed against — the things a physiotherapist must be able to do to register and practise. It's well worth reading them before you apply.

Do I really need the cultural competency courses?

Yes — evidence of cultural competency training (typically two courses) is part of registration. They're online and within your control, so they're one of the easiest things to get done early.

What if my curriculum doesn't cover every competency?

On the General Pathway, the assessment runs in phases. If Phase 2 (the curriculum review) finds gaps, you reach Phase 3 and are told the specific competencies to demonstrate, with around three months to provide detailed evidence from your training or work. The competencies already shown don't need proving again, and the Board provides guidance and templates to help.

Can I work while my application is being assessed?

You cannot practise until you're registered *and* hold a current APC. Plan your move around that fact rather than assuming you can begin and sort registration out afterwards.

Can Ethicare review my application?

Yes. We can review your documents and competency evidence before submission against what the Board looks for, and flag likely issues while they're still easy to fix. The registration decision always rests with the Board.

Your registration journey

From first decision to first day at work — here is the whole journey on a single page. Keep it nearby; it's the map you'll return to throughout.

Decision to move

You commit to building your career in New Zealand.



Confirm your pathway

Express, TTMR or General — the route that fits you.



Cultural competency courses

Complete these early — they're within your control.



Prepare documents

Gather, certify and date everything as a set.



Submit your application

Via MyPBNZ, with the CV on the Board's template.



Assessment

Against the Practice Thresholds; evidence phase if needed.



Registration (General Scope)

Confirmed by the Registrar; HPI number issued.



Annual Practising Certificate

Apply via MyPBNZ — you may now practise.



Applying for jobs

Secure the right role with registration in hand.



Visa & relocation

Immigration and settlement support arranged.



Starting work

Begin your new role and long-term future.

HOW ETHICARE WILL SUPPORT YOU

You don't have to navigate this alone

If you choose to partner with Ethicare, we'll support you from first enquiry through registration to relocation and your first day at work — with a single point of contact, honest guidance, and help at every stage. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the Physiotherapy Board of New Zealand.

READY TO BEGIN?

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